

me. I have some very important and urgent work to finish, and the damn thing refuses to start." And Mangesh being the almighty Hardware God (and he knows it) would of course reply with "Yeah, you know what? I'm watching *Farscape*, and it would be great if you could call back in an hours' time, so later, okay?" Of course you'll call back, because you know that if anyone can solve your problem, it's him.

So how do these guys get into technology? Is there an induction ceremony to be performed, complete with pacts that have to be sealed with blood on full moon nights? Chris, a self-confessed hardware lover explains, "I'm not sure how it all happened. It started out when the family Hewlett-Packard P2400 was acting up. I had to get a new motherboard, then some RAM. I started researching so that I could build the next PC from scratch. From that point on I have just been hooked on to hardware. At first, it was only the desire to run the latest games but later it grew into an all-consuming hobby."

There is an evolution angle to it too, as Chris adds: "Now I am more interested in getting the most performance from lower-end parts rather than buying the best—this is much more fun and easier on the wallet."

Chris, all of 16 years of age, already knows his SMPS from his SMTP. A gamer at heart, is he able to balance his studies and his passion? "I try not to place studies too high. Since I plan on getting a career in gaming, my game time becomes my study time. But so far I have

and will be able to game all I want. So I just keep thinking about that." Does he plan to move out and change cities? "I'm trying to get into a college in the US, so I guess that could be considered changing cities."

But riding the hardware ride is an expensive thrill. Every six months or so, there is something new on the scene—a new video card, a faster processor, and if you are into gadgets in general, the temptations are many and avenues of escape, very few. Being a 16-year-old, what do his parents think about all this? More importantly where does he get the money from? "I am lucky. My dad likes computers and uses them a lot so he doesn't mind the upgrade cycle; I don't spend money on much else, so most of it goes into computers," says Chris.

If it isn't broken, tweak it

Overclocking is the art of running your computer at speeds much faster than they were meant to run. It's akin to tuning the engine of your car for better performance, or replacing the engine altogether for that my-Maruti-800-can-go-faster-than-your-Ford-Ikon bragging rights. Overclocking falls into the much broader category of modding (geek-speak for modification). It is a process not without its risks, so why do it? "Why? I wanted the best performance for the lowest possible price. It is amazing what one can do when limited to a

Utkarsh is like talking to a Chris clone—they share the same love for hardware and games, even their tastes in music run similar, and both of them overclock and modify their computers. Utkarsh chips in: "It is the desire to experiment,



Utkarsh Dalmia
HARDWARE FREAK

“Power excites and just having a powerful system at my disposal gives me immense satisfaction”

to optimise. I want the best experience possible from my computer, so when I upgrade, it is always cutting edge. For example, my next upgrade will be before *DOOMIII*. Right now, no game can stress my PC."

So the driving force is the games then? "Not really, sometimes it's just for the testosterone feed. Power excites and just having a powerful system at my disposal gives me immense satisfaction. It is like zipping at high speeds in a Ferrari." But before we put this down as a need for speed, at whatever cost, Utkarsh clarifies, "It's a balance between practicality and desire—you can never have the fastest computer for long. Newer stuff releases every week, so buy what you can afford and then tweak it to get the performance you desire!"

Utkarsh also has a fairly elaborate scheme to source his money: "I lived in Singapore for about six months. You can buy the latest hardware at half the price you'd have to pay here. My dad has an office there, and some old college friends; so the *modus operandi* is that I do the price search online, decide what I want, and then import it to India". And if you thought that the custom duty would be a killer, Utkarsh has that covered too: "...just put it in a bag or two, no problem"! After six months or so, when it is time to upgrade, Utkarsh sells his old hardware in India at a premium; then uses the net amount to fund his next object of desire. It is a beautiful cycle that works for Utkarsh. What about his nagging parents? Any lectures on saving money? "...lots of lectures, but I plan my purchases at birthdays, or when I get good grades. And basically, since I don't



Chris, Hardware Freak

done okay, although there have been a few times when I have had a gaming spree and neglected my studies." So are there times in his life when he would rather be playing games than anything else? "Well, sometimes I do feel like that, but it's not going to be for much longer. I'll soon have my own PC and a house,

“There have been a few times when I've neglected studies while on a gaming spree. But I have eventually recovered”

small amount of resources and a lot of time." Chris and modding are inseparable. The only thing that comes close to his passion for modifications is an equally fervent desire to overclock his PC.

For some people budget is not the only reason. Take the case of Utkarsh Dalmia. He is 19 years old, lives in a different part of the country, but talking to